

CREATING HUMAN COMMUNITY

IF ONE THING, MORE THAN ANY OTHER, distinguishes a real neighbourhood from the corporate machine-architecture of the 20th-century developer, it is the fact that real people have - together - conceived it, planned it, and built it.

It is this human reality which makes it worth living in, pleasant to be there, and valuable.

This means that the entire adventure of building a neighbourhood – whether rebuilding an existing one, or building an entirely new one from scratch – can only be done successfully by reversing the usual process. The corporate procedure is to build the houses first, and then fill them with people later. Those houses inevitably remain box-like because they were mass produced without human engagement. It is building a human community and the physical buildings gradually and, above all **together**, that produces a living neighbourhood. As the buildings are thought of, planned, and built, so the involvement of the people who are going to inhabit them and use them – the community – is also thought of, and planned, and built. They are delicately and sensitively allowed to grow, so that buildings and people – or people and buildings – **grow together**.

We can only build thriving neighbourhoods by first building the human community that will create them with inspiration, heart and passion. When people know that they will live in the physical environment they are making together, and it is being made to support their way of living, they invest themselves in a remarkable way, and the place they create becomes one of belonging. There is no shortcut to achieving this outcome.

The process cannot be faked.

THE BENEFIT OF TAKING TIME

The capacity to generate life in a neighbourhood, comes in part, from slowness. People need a chance to adapt to one another's actions. This does not mean that it takes 100 years to build a neighbourhood. We have done it effectively in two or three years, and in our experience that can allow enough time for some mutual adaptation to occur step by step.

But it does mean that it is important not to be obsessed by speed. The desire to build at once comes from issues of banking, interest rates, and the desire for profit. Surely these matters can be brought under control, so that they no longer interfere with the birth of community -- a more significant issue.

PLANNING AND BUILDING TOGETHER AS A SOURCE OF FRIENDSHIP AND LIFE-ENHANCING COOPERATION	Our emotions are deeply rooted in our surroundings. Our social and personal connections to one another are connected to the shape and character of our environment and our individual relationships with the environment. When we create the physical substance of our environment, as a personal matter, we then become rooted in that world that we create, and in doing so we then become joined together with the fellows, friends, family and colleagues with whom we do it. Thus, the environment cannot be regarded merely as an object. It is the manifestation of our love for the earth, of our desires, of our affection for one another, and of our understanding of the universe. Of course an abstract, developer-built neighbourhood cannot do this for us. And indeed, we are now surrounded by buildings which cannot do it - and so, small wonder - the bond to the universe and to our fellows has been weakened. To allow this inner essence of the world, to be reborn, we must both create the world, and do it together with our fellows. When partners in a community engage in making a generative code, planning, and building together, they embrace a living process that brings with it the deepest kind of community building. They create both a social structure and a physical structure that holds the community together because, along with the contributions of all the people in various roles, the deeply held values and culture of the neighbourhood are built into the physical form. The outcome – the physical form – serves to reinforce on a daily basis an appreciation for what can be built out of shared vision and commitment, an appreciation for one another, and the restoration of mental and emotional health in the inhabitants as well as the physical surroundings.
VITAL SPECIFICATION	All the materials and processes described on this site emphasize the need for people to be partners in a <u>true</u> sense -- that means, that they are to be taken seriously, each one of them, <u>as a part of</u> the proceedings and creative effort. Please take this specification seriously!
PERSONAL FEELING	A short Note from Chris (see below, or click for web-link) describes the human under-structure of community, and the way this under-structure liberates the possibility of unfolding and morphogenesis, then allowing a real neighbourhood to form itself in human and geometric terms.

BUILDING ON RELATIONSHIP

A note from Chris Alexander

Human relationship. There are two fundamentally different ways of understanding the word "relationship," when it comes to human beings.

- One of these ways is **conventional**: this can describe the relationships you have with a shopkeeper, or a policeman, or a banker, or, in very sad cases, with a parent, a spouse, a son or daughter. These relationships are instrumental relationships; they are typically defined by convention – by the rules of behaviour as set out by custom or by society.
- The other way is **personal**: the essence of the relationship is that you seek, and find, a connection; you treat the other person as nearly as possible to the way you treat yourself, and you strive constantly to treat the other person more as you treat yourself. You recognize, and slowly come to feel, that you are part of the other person, and that the other person is a part of you, so that the two of you are gradually experiencing each other as an indivisible self.
- This is not only something that happens with a person who is very dear to you. You can have this quality of relationship even sitting next to a person on a park bench for only a few moments, when the exchange is something real.

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Oddly enough, there is a connection between the process of unfolding, the use of generative codes, and the character of the human relationships you choose.

- If you carefully build relationship, in the second, truer sense, one by one, step by step, with each person you encounter, then gradually the process and understanding of unfolding, will emerge, almost by itself.
- I know this to be true, just from experience. Somehow the deep understanding of how things in the world unfold, emerges from each person in a group, naturally, when there relationships are real.
- It is, I think, because when relationship is real, each person feels able to express what is going on without fear. There is no inhibition from mental constraint; the notion of what must happen in a process of development is not clutched, fearful or uptight, but rather what seems right and natural can flow from the situation.
 - That is, of course, what happens as things unfold.
 - It arises from acceptance of reality, without imposing mental structures.

In any case I do know from experience that when people are in this kind of relationship, understanding of unfolding then slowly pervades the situation, and the more beautiful and natural structures are allowed to appear in the land. On the other hand, if the relationships that are present are formal, or institutional, relationships then acceptance of what is real is not allowed to exist, and the resulting mesh of mental constraint is so rigid, sometimes even slightly nasty, the most ordinary things are not allowed to appear.

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Unfolding of life then appears of its own accord, almost automatically. Generative codes, and the unfolding which proceeds from them, then appear of their own accord, almost automatically, simply as a direct result of the personal relationships which govern people's minds.

This is a very beautiful result.

And, sadly, vice versa. In institutional settings, governmental settings, many business settings, the reverse is true. Since the setting guarantees that people cannot feel for each in a way that allows true things to be felt and said, then the result, so often – far, far too often – is a scrambled mess. Intellect cannot solve it. Living environments can hardly ever be born.

This is a very sad result, but true.

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As I get older, what has astonished me, lately, is the dramatic speed of the effect. One beats one's head against the wall, for years, within the institutional and business context, and never quite manages to loosen it sufficiently, in human terms, to get the desired results. But if you start, without worrying about the results so much, and focus attention only on the building of these true and personal relationships, one by one, then, as if a lever in a mountain stream had unleashed a cascade of water, the process of natural and harmonious unfolding is loosened and happens as if by a miracle.

This is so strong, it is worth taking very seriously indeed, and worth putting it first.